

WHAT IS SPERT® STORY MAP?

SPERT® Story Map is a browser-based agile release planning tool that replaces spreadsheet-driven story mapping workflows. It organizes work in a three-level hierarchy (**Theme** → **Backbone** → **Rib Item**) and connects your product backlog to releases, sprints, and progress tracking — all in one place. Use it to plan, size, assign, and track delivery of your product backlog across releases.

Theme	The highest-level grouping — a major capability area or product theme. Each theme can optionally be assigned one of 8 colors (blue, teal, violet, rose, amber, emerald, indigo, orange) for visual differentiation on the story map. Each theme header has a + button to add a backbone directly to that theme.
Backbone item	A feature or user activity under a theme. Backbone items span releases and contain rib items. Names wrap up to two lines on the Map for readability.
Rib item	The finest-grained work unit. Has a t-shirt size (XS → XXXL), a category (Core / Non-core), release allocations, sprint-by-sprint progress tracking, and an optional free-text notes field (up to 2,000 characters).
Release	A named delivery milestone with an optional target date. Rib items are assigned to releases with a percentage allocation (single release = 100%, or split across multiple releases).
Sprint	A time-boxed iteration with a name and end date. Used to record incremental progress on each rib item's release allocation.

■ **Tip:** Create your Themes, Backbones, and Rib Items in the Structure tab first — then assign them to releases in the Releases tab and track sprint progress in the Progress tab. You can also build the full hierarchy directly on the Map tab, or use **Connect AI** to let a compatible AI assistant build the map, create releases, and size rib items for you in bulk.

STEP-BY-STEP WORKFLOW

#	Tab / Page	What to do
1	Projects	Create a product. Click New Product , give it a name and optional description. Products are listed as tiles on the home screen. Drag to reorder. Each tile shows always-visible action icons: Share (cloud mode, owners only), Export, Duplicate, and Delete. Use Export All Projects (header button) to download all products as a single JSON backup.
2	Structure	Build your hierarchy. Add Themes, then Backbone items under each theme (use the + button on each theme header or the global + Backbone button), then Rib items. Assign a t-shirt size and Core/Non-core category. Drag to reorder any level.
3	Settings	Configure Releases (delivery milestones with optional target dates) and Sprints (iterations with end dates and cadence). Set the Size Mapping (points per t-shirt size) and project name/description.
4	Releases	Assign rib items to releases via the Kanban board. Drag cards across columns. Use Split Allocation to divide a rib item's effort across multiple releases with percentage splits. Change Core/Non-core directly in the allocation modal.
5	Progress	After each sprint, record percent-complete for each rib item per release. Select the sprint, enter progress values, and optionally add assessment notes. View burn-up charts and delta tracking.

Note: Undo (Ctrl+Z) is available for all edits within the session, but does not persist across page refreshes. Export a JSON backup before making major structural changes.

VIEWS & KEY FEATURES

Structure tab

Grid editor for the Theme → Backbone → Rib hierarchy. Inline editing, drag-to-reorder, t-shirt size picker, Core/Non-core toggle per rib item. Collapse themes to hide their backbones and ribs. Stats (points, % complete) per theme and backbone.

Map tab

Click a card to open its slide-out detail panel; click-and-hold anywhere on the card to drag it — no separate grip handle. On hover, three icons appear at the card's top-right: **color**, **clone**, and **delete**. The Core/Non-Core label anchors at the bottom-right. Rib names and backbone names each wrap up to two lines. Release labels appear on both left and right edges — double-click either to rename; single-click opens the release detail panel. Each release lane has a  collapse toggle (collapsed lanes show name and card count); a **Collapse releases / Expand all** button at the top-right controls all lanes at once. Hover any cell — including empty cells inside release lanes — to reveal a contextual **+ Rib** button. The **clone** icon duplicates with the same size, category, description, notes, and allocations but fresh progress. Smart naming: 'Task' → 'Task (1)' → 'Task (2)'. The **color** icon opens a picker with 7 card flag colors (red, orange, yellow, green, blue, purple, gray) or clear. A collapsible **color legend** floats in the bottom-right of both Map and Sizing tabs when any card is colored; click a label to edit its meaning in-place. Drag rib cards 2D (across release lanes and backbone columns simultaneously), backbone headers (horizontal), or theme headers (horizontal). Drag the handle beside a release label to reorder lanes vertically. The slide-out detail panel shows editable name, category, description, size, notes, and allocation breakdown.

Sizing tab

Click any card to open its edit dialog; click-and-hold to drag it into a t-shirt size column (XS–XXXL). Unsized cards live in the top zone, organized in an Excel-style grid with A/B/C column letters and 1/2/3 row numbers for easy reference. Sized columns expand to fill the available canvas width. Rib names show up to two lines. A collapsible filter panel sits below the zoom controls: **theme chips** (multi-select), **release chips** (multi-select — hides unallocated ribs when active), and a **Hide completed** toggle. Filter state **persists across tab navigation** per project (session storage; clears on browser refresh or tab close). Filter badge count reflects all active filters. A **+ Rib** button in the overlay opens a create modal with cascading theme → backbone → name selectors; smart defaults pre-fill when the active filter narrows to one choice. Card color is also available from the **+ Rib** modal and the **Edit** dialog. Each card exposes a **three-dot options menu** (top-right) with **Edit** (name, description, category, size, notes — prefilled), **Split** (creates a sibling rib in the same backbone with an (N) suffix), and **Delete** (confirmation dialog). For locked cards (progress > 0%): drag-to-resize is disabled and the size field in Edit is read-only, but the card is still **clickable to edit** name, description, category, and notes. Split and Delete remain available.

Releases tab

Kanban board — one column per release. Drag rib cards across columns to assign. Use **Split Allocation** to distribute effort across multiple releases by percentage (must total 100%). Toggle Core/Non-core in the allocation modal. Memos per allocation.

Rib item notes

Each rib item has a free-text notes field (up to 2,000 characters) accessible from the slide-out detail panel on the Map tab. Use it for requirements, acceptance criteria, reference links, or any per-item context. A character counter turns amber at 1,800 and red at 2,000. Notes save automatically on blur and appear in the XLSX export.

Progress tab	Sprint-by-sprint progress entry. Select a sprint, enter % complete per rib/release row. Group by release, backbone, or theme. View burn-up chart and delta from prior sprint. Add assessment notes (auto-timestamped) to any entry. Progress regression is allowed.
Insights tab	Analytics dashboard: total/core/non-core points, rib count, % complete, per-release breakdown (core vs. non-core stacked bars), sizing distribution, burn-up chart over time, and Attention Items (unsized, unassigned, or partially allocated ribs).
Settings tab	Manage releases (target dates, drag-to-reorder), sprints (end dates, cadence), size mapping (points per t-shirt label), project name/description. Data section: export/import JSON, Export to Excel (.xlsx — <i>Rib Items</i> sheet with Theme, Backbone, Name, Category, Size, Points, % Complete, Release(s), and Notes columns, plus a <i>Release Summary</i> sheet with totals and target dates; color-coded theme rows, frozen headers), Export for Forecaster. Sharing section (cloud mode only).
Connect AI	A Connect AI button in the project header pairs a compatible AI assistant with your open project to build or edit your story map in real time. Choose permissions — Write Mode (required) and Read Mode (optional: lets the AI see your current structure before editing) — then copy the pairing code and prompt and paste it into your AI assistant. Cards appear on your map as the AI works. The SPERT MCP server exposes 17 tools, including three bulk tools (storymap_bulk_create_releases , storymap_bulk_allocate , storymap_bulk_size) that collapse N individual calls into one — essential for large maps and AI clients that pause between calls. Pairing code expires in 15 minutes; click Disconnect when done. Undo (Ctrl+Z) works on AI-generated content. AI assistant must have the SPERT MCP server configured — see the <i>Connect AI Guide</i> .

RELEASE ALLOCATION & PROGRESS TRACKING

Single allocation	Drag a rib card into a release column to assign 100% of its effort to that release.
Split allocation	Click the split icon on a rib card to open the allocation editor. Distribute the rib's effort across multiple releases by percentage (must total 100%). Each allocation can carry an optional memo. Toggle Core/Non-core directly in the allocation modal.
Rib item notes	Each rib item has a free-text notes field (up to 2,000 characters) for requirements, acceptance criteria, or reference content. Open a rib card on the Map to access Notes in the slide-out detail panel. Saves automatically on blur.
Progress entry	In the Progress tab, enter % complete for each rib item per release, per sprint. Entering 0 or clearing removes the entry (unless a comment exists).
Delta tracking	The Progress tab shows the change in % complete since the prior sprint — helping the team see velocity and identify stalled items at a glance.
Burn-up chart	Cumulative completed points vs. total scope over sprints. Reflects scope changes automatically as rib items are added, sized, or re-allocated.
Assessment notes	Each progress entry supports an optional comment with auto-timestamp. Full history shown newest-first in an expandable panel.

Note: Progress regression is allowed — you can reduce a rib item's % complete to keep data honest. Rib items with progress > 0% are size-locked in the Sizing tab (drag-to-resize and the Edit modal size field are disabled to preserve points integrity), but the card is still clickable to edit name, description, category, and notes. Resize before recording sprint progress, or clear the progress entry first.

DATA & STORAGE

Local storage	Default. Data is stored in your browser only — never sent to any server. Safe for corporate data. An amber warning banner reminds you to export at the end of every session. Dismiss for the session with ×, or suppress it permanently via the Cloud Storage modal → Notifications. Clearing browser site data permanently deletes all products.
Cloud storage	Optional. Click the split-pill auth chip in the header to open the Cloud Storage modal — from any auth state (signed out, signed in, or signed in but on local mode). Sign in with Google or Microsoft. If you sign in but prefer to stay on local storage, a Keep using local storage button closes the modal without switching modes. Once in cloud mode, data syncs via Firebase across all your devices and enables project sharing with team members (owner / editor / viewer roles). Sign Out is reached through the modal's identity card; the chip updates in place with no page reload.
Export / Import (JSON)	Settings tab → Data: download a single product as a JSON backup. Import on the home page supports multi-project files with per-project resolution (skip, replace, or import-as-copy) — preview all projects before anything changes. Export All Projects (home page header) downloads every product as a single bundled JSON file in one click.
Export to Excel (XLSX)	Settings tab → Data → Export to Excel: generates a two-sheet .xlsx workbook. Rib Items sheet: one row per rib with Theme, Backbone, Name, Category, Size, Points, % Complete, Release(s), and Notes — color-coded theme header rows. Release Summary sheet: one row per release with totals, % Complete, core/non-core breakdown, and target date. Both header rows frozen.
Export for Forecaster	Settings tab → Data: export a product in SPERT® Release Forecaster import format — transforming releases into milestones with per-release backlog sizes and sprint velocity data.
Undo / Redo	Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Shift+Z. Up to 30 undo steps, in-memory only. Undo history resets on page refresh.
Dark mode	Click the sun/moon icon in the product header to toggle Light / Dark / System mode. System follows your OS preference. Choice is saved to localStorage.

■ **Tip:** Export a backup before sharing a product file with colleagues or before major structural changes. The Export Attribution fields (in the Cloud Storage modal) embed your name and identifier in exported files for team workflow traceability.

SIZE MAPPING & T-SHIRT SIZING

Rib items are sized using t-shirt labels that map to story points. The default mapping is configurable per product in Settings → Size Mapping. Points drive all calculations in the Insights and Progress tabs.

Size	Default Points	Notes
XS	5	Smallest unit — quick tasks, minor enhancements.
S	10	Small, well-understood feature with minimal unknowns.
M	20	Typical mid-size feature requiring design and test effort.
L	40	Large feature with meaningful complexity or dependencies.
XL	100	Very large feature; consider breaking into smaller rib items.
XXL	200	Epic-scale work — splitting is strongly recommended.
XXXL	300	Highest size tier. Use as a placeholder until fully decomposed.

Note: Rib items with progress > 0% are size-locked — drag-to-resize is disabled and the size field in the Edit modal is read-only, preserving historical points-vs-progress integrity. The card is still clickable to edit name, description, category, and notes. Resize before recording sprint progress, or clear the progress entry first.

TIPS, SHORTCUTS & ATTENTION ITEMS

Inline rename	Click any theme, backbone, rib item, or release label directly to rename it in-place. Press Enter to confirm or Escape to cancel. Double-click a release label on the Map to rename it (single-click opens the detail panel).
Map pan & zoom	On the Map and Sizing tabs, click and drag any empty area to pan — left-click only (right-click is reserved for the browser context menu and does not trigger panning). Mouse wheel or pinch gesture to zoom. Text cannot be accidentally highlighted while panning. A 'Drag to pan · Scroll to zoom' hint appears in the bottom-left corner for new users and auto-dismisses after the first successful pan.
Drag to reorder	Structure tab: drag themes, backbones, and rib items at any level. Map and Sizing tabs: click-and-hold anywhere on a card to drag it (rib cards move 2D on the Map — across release lanes and backbone columns simultaneously; backbone and theme headers move horizontally). A drag handle beside each release label lets you reorder lanes vertically — a blue insertion line shows the drop position. Releases tab: drag columns to reorder releases.
+ Rib shortcuts	In the Structure tab, + Rib immediately opens the detail panel with the name field focused for fast entry. On the Map, hover any cell — including empty cells in release lanes — to reveal a contextual + Rib button. On the Sizing tab, click the + Rib button in the overlay to open a create modal with cascading theme → backbone → name selectors.
Undo / Redo	Ctrl+Z undoes the last edit; Ctrl+Shift+Z redoes. Up to 30 steps, in-session only. Undo history resets on page refresh. Works on AI-generated content.
Collapse themes	In the Structure tab, click a theme's collapse toggle to hide its backbones and ribs — useful on large products with many themes.
Attention items	The Insights tab flags three categories: Unsize d (no t-shirt size), Unassigned (not in any release), and Partially allocated (percentages sum to less than 100%). Resolve all three for accurate point totals and burn-up data.
Theme colors	Assign one of 8 colors (blue, teal, violet, rose, amber, emerald, indigo, orange) to each theme in the Structure tab — these color Map headers and XLSX theme rows. Separate from theme colors, rib cards can also be individually flagged with one of 7 card flag colors (red, orange, yellow, green, blue, purple, gray) for team triage on the Map and Sizing tabs.
Progress grouping	In the Progress tab, switch the group-by selector to view progress by Release, Backbone, or Theme. Release grouping shows each rib's allocation row separately — useful for tracking split-allocated items. Backbone and Theme grouping give a higher-level picture. Expand or collapse individual groups for focused review.
Team workflow	In Cloud mode, share a product with teammates via Settings → Sharing, or click the Share icon on any project tile on the Projects page (cloud mode, owners only). Owners can add editors (full edit access) and viewers (read-only). Use Export Attribution (Cloud Storage modal) to embed your name and identifier in exported JSON files.

■ **Tip:** Use the Insights Attention Items panel as a pre-release health check: zero unsize, zero unassigned, and zero partially-allocated rib items means your release plan is fully specified and all point calculations are accurate.